

trades for the big boys of Dalal Street across rival groups. He was not a regular in the ring; he usually worked the phone to source and offload large blocks. At other times, his dealers would be seen bargaining in the ring. His clients trusted him on two counts: one, he would not front-run their trades (take advantage of their orders by putting in his own buy/sell orders, as used to often happen in the case of UTI ), and two, he would not discuss their trades with anybody. Govindbhai's business model was clear: he chose to make his money from plain vanilla broking, which did not entail any risk other than clients defaulting. He had multiple broking memberships and an office in Calcutta (now Kolkata). It was a rainy morning in late July when I walked into his office in one of the nondescript buildings on Nagindas Master Road, which sits at a right angle to the famed Dalal Street.

Govindbhai was of medium height, square-jawed, and had a broad forehead with hair slicked back, but what struck me were his unfriendly eyes. He was in his late thirties or early forties, and I had heard that he had been around for over fifteen years. I do not know if it had to do with his eyes, but there appeared to be a permanent scowl on his face. As I would learn later, it was just a facade. Govindbhai wanted to create an impression of being unapproachable. But he was a genial person once you got to know him, and he trusted you well enough. He had a wry sense of humour too, which I enjoyed a lot.

He greeted me with what I thought was a forced smile. Smiling did not come naturally to him. My first impression of him was of a man mistrustful of the world at large. We discussed the market for a few minutes, and that put me at ease somewhat.

'My friend has a good opinion of you, and I have heard about some of your exploits,' he said, smiling. This time the smile looked natural.

It was now my turn to force a weak smile. I did not know what to say.

'I know you are good at your work, Lala, because I rarely go by recommendations, even if they happen to come from some of my best friends,' he said. The smile had gone, to be replaced by the scowl. 'But let me also tell you that I prize integrity more than smartness. The nature of any broker's business demands that, as you know,' he said, now in a slightly more friendly tone.

'My staff is small, as you can see. I had two dealers, one of whom quit last month. I have two dealers in Calcutta too. I prefer a small team so that